

Unmasked | Dispatched

Game Design Document

Global Game Jam 2026
Theme: Masks

A First-Person Horror Puzzle Experience

1. Game Overview

1.1 High Concept

The Lask Mask is a short first-person psychological horror puzzle game set in an endless corridor maze. The player must escape using three ancient masks, each granting a powerful but single-use ability. Every mask worn is permanently lost, and using one at the wrong moment can trap the player forever.

"Is this the right moment to wear this mask?"

1.2 Core Pillars

- Irreversible Choice:** Every mask used permanently shapes the run
- Psychological Horror:** Fear through disorientation, scarcity, and consequence
- Environmental Puzzle Design:** Solutions hidden in observation and spatial awareness

1.3 Quick Reference

Attribute	Details
Genre	First-Person Horror Puzzle
Engine	Unreal Engine with Horror Engine Template
Platform	PC (Windows)
Target Playtime	10-15 minutes

Player Count Single Player

Perspective First-Person

1.4 Team Composition

Role	Responsibilities
Artist	Environment art, mask designs, UI, lighting
Generalist	Level design, puzzle implementation, playtesting, QA
Programmer	Mask system, game logic, UI programming, Horror Engine integration
Audio Engineer	Sound design, ambient audio, mask audio effects, music

2. Narrative Context

2.1 Setting

The player awakens in an impossibly vast maze of repeating corridors. The architecture defies logic: halls stretch into darkness, doors lead to rooms already visited, and the walls seem to shift when unobserved. This is not a place built by human hands.

Scattered throughout the maze are fragments of a forgotten ritual. Notes written in frantic handwriting hint at others who came before—all seeking escape, all failing. The maze is hungry, and it has been waiting.

2.2 The Masks

Three ancient masks rest on a pedestal at the maze's entrance. Each mask once belonged to someone who tried to escape. They succeeded in crafting tools of power but paid with their identities. The masks remember their creators, and wearing one means briefly becoming someone else.

The player is warned through environmental storytelling: these masks are powerful, but they are also prisons. Use them wisely, for once worn, they claim a piece of you forever.

2.3 Story Delivery

- Environmental storytelling through notes, symbols, and architecture
 - No cutscenes or dialogue; all narrative is discoverable
 - Horror Engine diary system for collectible lore fragments
 - The maze itself tells a story through its impossible geometry
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3. The 2 Masks

Each mask grants a powerful **15-second ability**. Once used, the mask is **permanently consumed**. The player must decide when each mask's power is worth the cost.

3.1 The Hollow Mask (Sight)

Attribute	Details
Visual Design	A featureless white mask with empty eye sockets that weep black tears
Ability	TRUE SIGHT: Reveals hidden paths, correct doors, and invisible clues for 15 seconds
Visual Effect	World shifts to high-contrast black and white; correct paths glow with ethereal light; hidden symbols become visible on walls; player's vision pulses as if seeing through dying eyes
Audio Effect	Whispered voices guide the player, growing desperate as time runs out
Mandatory Use	Act 2: The Labyrinth of Doors (correct door is invisible without mask)
Optional Uses	Act 1: Reveals shortcut through hidden passage; Act 3: Shows safe path through final corridor

3.3 The Fractured Mask (Form)

Attribute	Details
Visual Design	A cracked mask split down the middle, held together by black veins
Ability	PHASE: Allows passage through one sealed door, wall, or barrier for 15 seconds

Visual Effect	Player's hands become translucent; world gains a ghostly double-image effect; solid objects shimmer as if not quite real; screen edges distort and warp
Audio Effect	A low harmonic drone with crackling static, like reality tearing
Mandatory Use	Act 2: The Sealed Archive (only entrance is through a solid wall)
Optional Uses	Act 1: Skip locked gate puzzle entirely; Act 3: Phase through collapsed debris for shortcut

4. Maze Structure and Progression

4.1 Overall Flow

The maze is divided into three distinct acts, each with increasing tension and complexity. The player progresses linearly, though each section contains optional paths and mask-dependent shortcuts.

Act	Name	Duration	Mandatory Mask
Act 1	The Threshold	3-4 minutes	None
Act 2	The Deep Maze	5-7 minutes	Hollow + Fractured
Act 3	The Escape	3-4 minutes	Wailing

4.2 Act 1: The Threshold

Purpose

Introduce the player to the maze, establish atmosphere, teach basic mechanics, and tempt premature mask usage.

Environment

- Clean, almost sterile corridors that slowly become more degraded
- Flickering fluorescent lighting transitioning to dim candlelight
- Occasional windows showing impossible vistas (corridors stretching into infinity)

Key Moments

1. **The Awakening:** Player wakes on the floor, masks on pedestal ahead. Tutorial text on wall explains mask mechanics.
2. **First Choice:** A locked gate blocks progress. Player can solve a simple symbol-matching puzzle OR use the Fractured Mask to phase through. The puzzle is easy but time-consuming.
3. **The Whisper Room:** A room where audio cues hint at danger. An optional scare event triggers if the player makes noise. The Wailing Mask can prevent this, but it is not necessary.
4. **The Hidden Path:** An invisible shortcut exists that only the Hollow Mask can reveal. Without it, the player takes a longer scenic route.

Trap Design

All mask uses in Act 1 are **optional**. A careless player might use one or two masks here for convenience, not realizing they are mandatory later.

4.3 Act 2: The Deep Maze

Purpose

The core puzzle section. Two mandatory mask uses are required. This is where poor earlier choices result in softlocks.

Environment

- Architecture becomes more oppressive and illogical
- Corridors that loop back on themselves
- Rooms that change when the player looks away
- Increasing decay: cracked walls, rotting wood, strange organic growths

Key Moments

1. **The Labyrinth of Doors:** A circular room with seven identical doors. Six lead back to the entrance. The correct door is completely invisible without the Hollow Mask.
MANDATORY: Hollow Mask required.
2. **The Sealed Archive:** A room containing crucial lore and the exit key. The only entrance is a solid wall with scratch marks on the inside. **MANDATORY: Fractured Mask**

required.

3. **The Shifting Halls:** A section where corridors rearrange themselves. Observational puzzle based on tracking subtle environmental details. No mask required but very tense.
4. **The Creaking Bridge:** A noise-sensitive section over a bottomless pit. The Wailing Mask makes this trivial, but careful movement works without it.

Softlock Points

If the player reaches The Labyrinth of Doors without the Hollow Mask OR The Sealed Archive without the Fractured Mask, they cannot proceed.

4.4 Act 3: The Escape

Purpose

Final gauntlet with escalating tension. One mandatory mask use remains. The maze fights back.

Environment

- Near-complete darkness with only the player's flashlight
- Walls appear to breathe and shift
- Distant sounds of something massive moving
- Architecture becomes almost biological

Key Moments

1. **The Listening Hall:** A long corridor lined with pressure plates. Each step creates sound that triggers increasingly violent environmental reactions (debris falls, lights explode, floor cracks). **MANDATORY: Wailing Mask required.**
2. **The False Exit:** A door marked "EXIT" that leads to a loop back to Act 2's entrance. Environmental clues hint this is wrong if the player observes carefully.
3. **The Final Corridor:** A straight path to the true exit. If the player has the Hollow Mask, they can see it is safe. Without it, they must walk through darkness with no certainty. Atmospheric tension, no actual danger.
4. **Escape:** The player reaches the exit door. A final choice: open it and escape, leaving the masks behind forever.

Softlock Point

If the player reaches The Listening Hall without the Wailing Mask, they cannot proceed.

5. Softlock and Restart System

5.1 Detection Logic

The game tracks which masks have been consumed. At each mandatory checkpoint, the system verifies the required mask is still available.

Checkpoint	Required Mask	Trigger
Labyrinth of Doors entrance	Hollow Mask	Enter room
Sealed Archive wall	Fractured Mask	Approach wall
Listening Hall entrance	Wailing Mask	Enter corridor

5.2 Softlock UI Sequence

When a softlock is detected, the following sequence plays:

1. Screen slowly fades to black over 2 seconds
2. The mask the player needed appears center-screen, cracked and broken
3. Text fades in below: **"You wore the wrong face."**
4. After 3 seconds, additional text: **"The maze remembers."**
5. A **"Begin Again"** button appears with subtle animation
6. On click, hard restart to the beginning with all masks restored

5.3 Visual Design Notes for Softlock Screen

- Black background with subtle particle effect (floating ash or dust)
 - The broken mask should be the specific one that was needed
 - Text uses the same font as in-game notes for consistency
 - No music, only ambient wind or distant echoes
 - The button should pulse gently to draw attention without being jarring
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6. Puzzle Design Details

6.1 Design Principles

- All puzzles should be solvable through observation, not trial and error
- Audio and visual cues should guide without being explicit
- Puzzles should feel diegetic (part of the world, not gamey)
- Use Horror Engine's existing puzzle systems wherever possible

6.2 Puzzle Breakdown

Act 1: The Locked Gate

Type: Symbol Matching

Difficulty: Easy (1-2 minutes)

Description: Four symbols are scattered on nearby walls. The player must input them in the correct order on a panel beside the gate.

Solution: Symbols have numbers scratched faintly beside them indicating order.

Mask Alternative: Fractured Mask phases through the gate entirely (not recommended).

Act 2: The Labyrinth of Doors

Type: Perception Puzzle

Difficulty: Impossible without Hollow Mask

Description: Seven identical wooden doors in a circular room. Six lead back to the room's entrance. The seventh is the correct exit but is completely invisible to the naked eye.

Solution: Hollow Mask reveals the hidden seventh door glowing with ethereal light.

Environmental Hints: Scratches on the floor show previous victims walking in circles. A note reads: *"I can hear the right door. I just can't see it."*

Act 2: The Sealed Archive

Type: Traversal Puzzle

Difficulty: Impossible without Fractured Mask

Description: A room visible through a small crack in an otherwise solid wall. Inside is the key needed for the final exit. There is no door.

Solution: Fractured Mask allows the player to phase through the wall.

Environmental Hints: Scratch marks on the inside of the wall suggest someone was trapped within. A note outside reads: *"The walls here are not as solid as they pretend."*

Act 2: The Shifting Halls

Type: Memory/Observation Puzzle

Difficulty: Medium (3-4 minutes)

Description: A series of corridors that rearrange when the player is not looking. The player must reach the exit by tracking which paths have changed.

Solution: Environmental details persist (a knocked-over chair, a bloodstain) and can be used to identify which corridor is which.

No Mask Required: Pure environmental puzzle.

Act 3: The Listening Hall

Type: Stealth/Traversal

Difficulty: Impossible without Wailing Mask

Description: A long corridor where every sound triggers escalating environmental destruction. Normal walking triggers debris. Running triggers floor collapse.

Solution: Wailing Mask creates total silence, allowing safe passage.

Environmental Hints: Shattered remains of previous travelers who made too much noise. A note reads: *"It listens. It always listens."*

7. Horror Design

7.1 Horror Philosophy

Three Faces relies on **psychological horror** rather than constant scares. Fear should emerge from the player's own decisions and the oppressive atmosphere, not from sudden loud noises or monster chases.

7.2 Sources of Fear

Fear Source	Implementation
Disorientation	Looping corridors, impossible geometry, rooms that change subtly
Scarcity	Only three masks for the entire game; using one feels like losing something
Consequence	Wrong mask use leads to permanent failure; every choice has weight
Anticipation	The player dreads what might require a mask, not what is happening now
Isolation	No other characters, no help, only notes from those who failed before

The Unknown What are these masks? Why does the maze exist? Answers are never complete

7.3 Horror Engine Event System Usage

Use the Horror Engine event system to trigger atmospheric scares without scripting complex logic:

- Lights flickering when entering specific zones
- Distant footsteps that stop when the player stops moving
- Doors creaking open behind the player after they pass
- Whispers that fade in and out at random intervals
- Objects falling from shelves when the player's back is turned

7.4 What to Avoid

- Jumpscares that feel cheap or unearned
 - Constant loud noises (silence is more frightening)
 - Monster chases or action sequences (outside scope and tone)
 - Gore or shock imagery (psychological, not visceral)
 - Player death outside of softlock (failure comes from choices, not reflexes)
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8. Audio Design

8.1 Audio Pillars

- **Silence as a tool:** The absence of sound is often more frightening than its presence
- **Environmental storytelling:** Audio hints at what happened here before
- **Mask identity:** Each mask has a distinct, unsettling audio signature

8.2 Ambient Sound Layers

Layer	Elements
Base	Low frequency hum, almost subliminal, suggesting the maze is alive
Environmental	Creaking wood, dripping water, distant echoes, wind through unseen passages

Reactive	Sounds that respond to player actions (footsteps echoing differently per surface)
Event	One-shot sounds for scares and important moments

8.3 Mask Audio Signatures

Hollow Mask (Sight)

- **Activation:** Glass shattering, then ethereal choir fade-in
- **Active:** Whispered voices guiding, growing desperate as timer runs low
- **Deactivation:** Sharp inhale, then ringing silence

Wailing Mask (Sound)

- **Activation:** Scream that cuts to absolute silence
- **Active:** Only the player's heartbeat, growing louder and faster
- **Deactivation:** Sound floods back in, disorienting

Fractured Mask (Form)

- **Activation:** Crackling static, like reality tearing
- **Active:** Low harmonic drone, slightly out of tune, uncomfortable
- **Deactivation:** A "snap" as reality reasserts itself

8.4 Music Direction

Minimal melodic music. Instead, use evolving drones and textures that shift based on act:

- **Act 1:** Near-silence with occasional tonal hints
 - **Act 2:** Low, pulsing drones that increase in intensity at puzzle points
 - **Act 3:** Dissonant textures, almost painful, building toward escape
 - **Escape:** Total silence, then a single sustained note as the door opens
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9. User Interface

9.1 HUD Elements

Minimal HUD to maintain immersion:

- **Mask inventory:** Three mask icons in bottom-left corner, visible but unobtrusive. Used masks fade to silhouette.
- **Interaction prompt:** Simple "E" prompt when looking at interactable objects. Uses Horror Engine's existing system.
- **No health bar:** Player cannot die except through softlock.
- **No minimap:** Disorientation is part of the experience.

9.2 Mask Selection UI

When player presses mask selection key (recommend Tab or Q):

1. Game pauses with slight blur effect
2. Three masks appear in center screen, arranged horizontally
3. Available masks are lit; used masks are darkened and cracked
4. Hovering over a mask shows its name and brief ability description
5. Clicking a mask activates it; pressing Escape cancels selection

9.3 Softlock Screen

Described in detail in Section 5.2. Key elements:

- Full screen black with particle effects
- Centered broken mask image (the one that was needed)
- Thematic text: "You wore the wrong face." and "The maze remembers."
- Single "Begin Again" button with subtle pulse animation

9.4 Main Menu

- **New Game:** Starts fresh playthrough
- **Continue:** Disabled for this game (full restarts only)
- **Options:** Audio, display, controls
- **Quit:** Exit game

Menu background: Slow pan across a corridor with the three masks on a pedestal.

10. Technical Implementation

10.1 Horror Engine Systems to Use

System	Usage
First-Person Controller	Base player movement, camera, head bob, crouch
Interaction System	Picking up notes, interacting with puzzle elements
Diary/Note System	Collectible lore fragments throughout the maze
Puzzle System	Symbol matching puzzles, button sequences
Door System	Locked doors, keys, the final exit
Horror Events	Triggered scares, environmental reactions
Lighting System	Flickering lights, light explosions, darkness zones
Portal System	Connecting maze sections, creating loops
Flashlight	Player's primary light source in Act 3

10.2 Custom Systems Required

Mask Manager (Blueprint/C++)

- Track which masks are available (array of 3 booleans)
- Handle mask activation (trigger effects, start 15-second timer)
- Handle mask deactivation (end effects, mark mask as used)
- Expose mask state to UI and checkpoint system

Mask Effect Controllers (Per Mask)

- **Hollow Mask:** Post-process material swap, reveal hidden actors, audio trigger
- **Wailing Mask:** Audio suppression, post-process desaturation, disable sound triggers
- **Fractured Mask:** Enable collision ignore for specific barriers, post-process distortion

Softlock Detector

- Trigger volumes at mandatory checkpoints
- On overlap, check if required mask is available
- If not, trigger softlock UI sequence

Hidden Object System (Hollow Mask)

- Actors tagged as "HollowVisible" are invisible by default
- When Hollow Mask is active, these actors become visible
- Used for the correct door in Labyrinth of Doors and other secrets

10.3 Performance Considerations

- Use level streaming for maze sections to manage memory
 - Limit real-time lighting; bake where possible
 - Post-process effects for masks should be lightweight
 - Target 60 FPS on mid-range hardware
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11. Scope Management

11.1 Must Have (Core Experience)

- Three functional masks with distinct effects
- Linear maze with three acts
- Three mandatory mask checkpoints with softlock detection
- Softlock UI screen with restart
- Basic atmospheric audio and lighting
- At least one environmental puzzle per act
- Playable start to finish in 10-15 minutes

11.2 Should Have (If Time Permits)

- Full lore notes throughout the maze
- Optional mask uses that create shortcuts
- Polished mask activation/deactivation animations
- Environmental scare events using Horror Engine
- Multiple ambient audio layers

11.3 Could Have (Stretch Goals)

- Additional optional puzzles
- Multiple endings based on mask usage pattern
- Post-game statistics screen (masks used, time taken)

- Speedrun timer mode

11.4 Won't Have (Out of Scope)

- Monster AI or chase sequences
 - Combat or player death (except softlock)
 - Voice acting
 - Procedural maze generation
 - Multiplayer
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12. Development Schedule

Assuming a **48-hour game jam window**:

Hours 0-8: Foundation

- Set up project with Horror Engine template
- Block out all three acts with placeholder geometry
- Implement basic mask manager system
- Create mask selection UI prototype

Hours 8-20: Core Systems

- Implement all three mask effects
- Build mandatory puzzles (Labyrinth, Archive, Listening Hall)
- Implement softlock detection and UI
- First playable build for internal testing

Hours 20-32: Content and Polish

- Environment art pass on all areas
- Implement optional puzzles and shortcuts
- Audio implementation (ambient, masks, events)
- Lighting pass for atmosphere

Hours 32-44: Integration and Testing

- Full playthroughs to verify all paths work

- Bug fixing and edge case handling
- Balance timing and difficulty
- Add lore notes if time permits

Hours 44-48: Final Polish

- Main menu and credits
 - Final audio mix
 - Build and test final executable
 - Prepare submission
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13. Appendix: Mask Usage Flowchart

The following table shows all possible mask usage scenarios and their outcomes:

Mask Usage Before Act 2	Outcome
No masks used	All paths available; optimal run
Wailing used (optional scare skip)	Can complete game; hardest ending (no silence in Act 3)
Hollow used (shortcut)	SOFTLOCK at Labyrinth of Doors
Fractured used (gate skip)	SOFTLOCK at Sealed Archive
Two+ masks used	Guaranteed SOFTLOCK at some point

Key insight: The only masks that can be "safely" used in Act 1 are **none**. Any mask used before Act 2 risks softlock except the Wailing Mask, which merely makes Act 3 mandatory (and extremely tense) without its help.

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